

Session 13: Eating Sour Grapes

Key Takeaways

- Ezekiel is not making an argument about personal responsibility. He's crafting a principle to address the blame-shifting attitude in the entire community.
- The remnant in Jerusalem is suffering the consequences of their own generation's unfaithfulness. Their suffering is not caused by the sins of their parents.
- The Israelites blaming their ancestors for their situation replays the blame-shifting theme of Genesis 3.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 18

Ezekiel 18:1-20

A Dispute About Generational Sin and Its Consequences

18:1-4

- The Proverb: Children suffer the consequences of their parents' sins
- Yahweh: The person who sins, that's the one who faces the consequences

18:5-17

Three Case Studies

- **5-9** Generation 1: A righteous father—he does good—he will live
- **10-13** Generation 2: A violent son—he does evil—he will die
- **14-17** Generation 3: A righteous grandson—he does good—he will live

18:18-20

- Israel's response: The son is suffering for his parent's sins?
- Yahweh: No, the person who sins, that's the one who faces the consequences.

Ezekiel 18:21-29

A Dispute About a Person's Own Sin and the Consequences

18:21-23

- Example 1: A wicked man who turns from his sins ... he will find life

18:24

- Example 2: A righteous man who turns away to evil ... he will die

18:25-29

- Israel's response: The way of Yahweh is not right!
- Yahweh brings consequences based on people's own choices

Ezekiel 18:30-32

Yahweh's Appeal to Israel: Turn to Me and Live!

- **18:30** Yahweh is rendering judgment on Israel based on these principles
- **18:31** So turn, Israel, and find life!
- **18:32** God's will is that people turn to him and find life.

Ezekiel 18:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

¹ And the word of Yahweh came to me, saying,

² " **What do y'all mean by proverb'ing this proverb about the land of Israel, saying ,**
' The fathers eat the sour grapes ,
but it's the children's teeth that stick to each other '?

³ "As I live," declares Yahweh Elohim,
"you will no longer proverb this proverb in Israel anymore.

⁴ Look, all living-beings belong to me;
the being of the father as well as the being of the son belong to me.

The living-being who sins, that's the one who will die .

Generation #1: A Righteous Father

⁵ So a man, if he is righteous,
and does what is just and right,

⁶ he does not eat at the mountain shrines,
or lift up his eyes to the dung-balls of the house of Israel,
or defile his neighbor's wife
or come on to his wife during her menstrual period,

⁷ or oppress another person,
but restores to the debtor his pledge,
does not commit robbery,
but gives his bread to the hungry
and covers the naked with clothing,

⁸ if he does not lend money on interest,
or take increase,
if he keeps his hand from iniquity
and renders true justice between every person,
⁹ if he walks in my statutes
and keeps my ordinances so as to practice true,
that one is righteous,
and **he will surely live** ;”
declares Yahweh Elohim.

Generation #2: A Wicked Son

¹⁰ “Now, he might have a violent son,
who sheds blood,
and who does any of these things to a brother,
¹¹ (though the brother himself did not do any of these things),
and he eats at the mountain shrines,
and he defiles his neighbor’s wife,
¹² he oppresses the poor and needy,
he commits robbery,
he does not restore a pledge,
but lifts up his eyes to the idols and commits abomination,
¹³ he lends money on interest
and he takes increase ... **will he live** ?
He will not live!
He has committed all these abominations,
he will surely be **put to death** ;
his blood will be on his own head.

Generation #3: A Righteous Grandson

¹⁴ Now look, he could have a son,
and the son sees all the sins that his father is doing,
and upon seeing, he does not do likewise.
¹⁵ He does not eat at the mountain shrines,
and he doesn’t lift up his eyes to the idols of the house of Israel,
or defile his neighbor’s wife,
¹⁶ he doesn’t oppress anyone,
or keep a pledge,
or commit robbery,
but he gives his bread to the hungry,
and he covers the naked with clothing,
¹⁷ he keeps his hand from the poor,
he does not take interest or increase,

but practices my ordinances,
and he walks in my statutes;
he will not die for his father's iniquity;
he will surely live .

¹⁸ As for his father,
because he practiced extortion,
robbed his brother
and did what was not good among his people,
look, **he will die** for his iniquity.

¹⁹ **But y'all say ,**
Why should the son not carry the punishment for the father's iniquity? "

Well, the son practiced justice and righteousness,
and he has observed all My statutes and done them;
he shall surely live .

²⁰ **The living-being who sins, that's who will die.**

The son will not bear the punishment for the father's iniquity,
nor will the father bear the punishment for the son's iniquity;
the righteousness of the righteous will be upon himself,
and the wickedness of the wicked will be upon himself.

Example #1: A Wicked Man Who Turns

²¹ Now, if the wicked man turns from all his sins which he has committed,
and if he observes all my statutes,
and practices justice and righteousness,
he will surely live ;

he will not die .

²² All his transgressions which he has committed will not be remembered against him;
because of his righteousness which he has practiced,
he will live .

²³ "Do I have any pleasure in the **death** of the wicked?"
declares Yahweh Elohim,
"Wouldn't I rather he turn from his ways and **live** ?

Example #2: A Righteous Man Who Turns

²⁴ Now, when a righteous man turns away from his righteousness,
and commits iniquity according to all the abominations that a wicked man does,
will he live ?

All his righteous deeds which he has done will not be remembered,
because for his treachery which he has committed,
and because of his sin which he has committed;
for these **he will die** .

25 But y'all say ,
'The way of Yahweh is not right.'
Listen now, O house of Israel !
Is it my way that's not right ?
Isn't it your ways that are not right ?

26 When a righteous man turns away from his righteousness,
and commits iniquity
and **dies** because of it,
it's for his iniquity that he has committed that **he will die** .

27 And when a wicked man turns away from his wickedness which he has committed,
and he practices justice and righteousness,
he will **save his life** .

28 Because he saw and turned away from all his transgressions which he had committed,
he will surely live ;
he will not die .

29 But the house of Israel says ,
'The way of Yahweh is not right.'
Are my ways not right, O house of Israel ?
Isn't it your ways that are not right ?

30 "Therefore, 'each according to his way,'
that's how I will bring justice on y'all you, O house of Israel,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.

"Repent and turn away from all your transgressions,
so that iniquity may not become a stumbling block to you.

31 Cast away from you all your transgressions which you have committed,
and make yourselves a new heart and a new spirit!
For why should y'all **die** , O house of Israel?

32 For I have no pleasure in the death of anyone who **dies** ,"
declares Yahweh Elohim.

"So then, turn back, and **find life** ."

Ezekiel 18:1-32. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Disputing the Parable About Generational Guilt

Ezekiel takes on the widespread ideas among exiled Israel that prevent them from fully owning their responsibility for Jerusalem's destruction and from seeing any reason to turn back to Yahweh for hope. These ideas are summarized in the "sayings" Ezekiel quotes and refutes.

In 18:1-20, Ezekiel challenges the idea of generational guilt. The people say, "The parents eat sour grapes, and the children's teeth are set on edge." In 18:2, "set on edge" comes from the Septuagint's translation of the

same proverb quoted by Jeremiah in [Jeremiah 31:29](#) (or 38:29 in the Old Greek) as *αἰμωδιάω* “to become contracted, to be set on edge,” referring to the seizure of mouth muscles when eating really sour things.

The basic meaning of this proverb is that when children suffer, it’s because of their parents’ bad decisions. In Ezekiel’s context, this proverb is saying that many Israelites are suffering in Babylonian exile, but it’s the result of covenant violations of earlier generations (specifically Manasseh, see [1 Kgs. 21](#)). The implication is that Ezekiel’s generation is not responsible for the disaster, even though they are suffering the consequences.

This is a blame-shifting mentality that blinds the exiles to their own contribution (chapters 8-11!) to their circumstances.

Yahweh's Response Through Ezekiel

Yahweh adopts a principle from Israel’s criminal law: When an individual commits a crime, that individual is the one who should suffer the consequences, not another family member.

Deuteronomy 24:16 NIV

Parents are not to be put to death for their children, nor children put to death for their parents; **each will die for their own sin.**

What’s fascinating is that Ezekiel takes this legal principle and applies it to a situation that is not a clear-cut criminal case. Rather, he applies it to Israel’s communal experience of disaster and Babylonian exile. Ezekiel’s contemporaries deny any responsibility for the situation, and so the argument presented in Ezekiel 18 is a rhetorical effort to persuade them otherwise.

To convince the Israelites that their own sins contributed to the disaster of the exile, he uses a legal principle and argues backwards.

- Premise: It’s the guilty party that suffers for a crime.
- Premise: The present generation is suffering in Babylonian exile.
- Conclusion: The present generation is guilty of a crime.

This generation has perpetuated the same as their fathers. In 18:4, “... the individual human who sins, that is the one who will die,” implies that if the people are being “put to death” in exile (see the dry bones of [Ezek. 37](#)), it is for their own decisions. Yahweh’s response is “Stop blame-shifting!”

Ezekiel’s Case Study of Three Generations

Ezekiel extends the argument through a case study exploring God’s response to people’s righteousness, rebellion, and repentance. The case study tests three generations: a righteous father, a wicked son, and a righteous grandson who does not die for his father’s sins.

The implication of this case study is that the exiles think they are the righteous grandson (generation #3), but Ezekiel is trying to show them they are the wicked son (generation #2)!

“Ezekiel addresses the question of his audience: if the present generation were righteous, they would not be suffering; since they are suffering, this must be because of their own sins. Ezekiel’s hearers cannot be

the righteous sons of wicked fathers, as they suppose themselves to be ... Ezekiel is not concerned here with a theory of moral individualism in contrast to collective responsibility. He takes for granted the legal principle of 'individual responsibility' and he employs it in his three hypothetical cases, but the possibility of Yahweh judging individuals in isolation from their contemporaries is never considered. This is because the question at issue is a different one, namely, 'Why did this national crisis happen,' a crisis that is by definition, communal."

Joyce, Paul (1989). [*Divine Initiative and Human Response in Ezekiel*](#). Bloomsbury T&T Clark. 46.

The literary placement of chapter 18 between chapters 17 and 19 is surely intentional, as both of these poems trace the final generations of Judah's kings (Josiah, Manasseh, Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, Zedekiah) who display a case study in generational guilt (see 2 Kgs. 21-25).

The Exiles' Response

In 18:19, the people reply, "What do you mean the child does not bear responsibility for the sin of the parent?!" This line is not a defense of this idea as a legal principle, as if the people are advocating that children should be held accountable for their parents' actions. Rather, it's a statement of shock, because in their current view of reality, they are the righteous grandson who is suffering because of the wicked father.

"Here the people are pictured as demanding that 'the righteous son' (with whom they identify themselves) should suffer for the iniquity of the father! This is indeed paradoxical, and can only be explained by supposing that Ezekiel is suggesting that such a demand is implied by his audience's position stated in the earlier proverb. They have a vested interest in the correctness of the proverb. If it cannot be established that one generation suffers for the sins of previous generations, they will have to admit they are to blame for the current situation. They would prefer to go on believing in their own explanation for the disaster rather than admit responsibility ... The plea in v. 19 is a *reductio ad absurdum*, they would rather, it seems, that Yahweh be proven unjust than to admit that they themselves are guilty."

Joyce, Paul (1989). [*Divine Initiative and Human Response in Ezekiel*](#). Bloomsbury T&T Clark. 47-48.

It's as if they say, "Our proverb and our experience show that we are suffering for our parents' sin as we sit here in Babylon! What do you mean, Ezekiel, that the children are not responsible before God for the sin of their parents?!"

Ezekiel Challenges the Idea of Past Merit/Guilt

If Ezekiel's first argument claims that guilt and consequences do not transfer generationally, he now takes another angle. Even in the span of one person's lifetime, they are accountable for their posture toward Yahweh in the present moment, not for what happened in the past.

- Case study 1: A wicked man turns and does what is right, therefore he will live.
- Case study 2: A righteous man turns and does what is wrong, therefore he will die.

Ezekiel leads into his last point to the exiles in 18:21-24: The same choice that the son faced when he saw the behavior of his father (18:14) is the choice each person has when they reflect back on their own behavior through the years. A person's past sins do not determine their destiny if they turn and change. And a person's past virtue does not vindicate them if they are presently making terrible decisions (18:24).

Israel thinks this cannot be right (18:25). They are not disputing the legitimacy of Ezekiel's argument as a legal principle, but as a description of their experience of sitting in exile. In their mindset, they are currently the righteous and innocent ones who do not deserve to be sitting in "death," that is, in Babylonian exile. But Ezekiel's argument (much like Job's friends) is that their suffering tells a different story. The very fact that they're in exile means they were, in the time of their defeat, in a state of rebellion against Yahweh.

Ezekiel's Conclusion

Ezekiel 18:30 Instructor's Translation

So then, each according to their own ways, that is how I will render justice for y'all, house of Israel.

This line is crucial, as it makes clear that even though Ezekiel's legal case studies have focused on individuals, he is not working out a theory of individual responsibility for its own sake. Rather, the case studies are analogies for thinking about the people of Israel's collective experience of defeat and exile by Babylon.

The word "each" (אִישׁ) refers back to the individual "man" (אִישׁ) of the cases studies in 18:2-29, which were clearly an image of entire Israelite generations.

Before we make the jump from the case studies to our own cultural contexts, we need to see how Ezekiel applied the case studies to his audience. This will give us guidance on how to apply his wisdom appropriately and in alignment with his own purposes.

Ezekiel 18 Reflections

In this chapter, Ezekiel is offering profound prophetic and pastoral insight.

Our Moral Choices Do Not Take Place in a Vacuum

Ezekiel is not arguing that people's moral decisions bear no relation to their parents' failures. Rather, he's arguing that when we've made choices that result in disaster, we should not try to shift responsibility to the failures of others. At the same time, it's very clear that Ezekiel's generation adopted the patterns of idolatry from their ancestors, and so perpetuate a generational failure that results in the exile.

Real Moral Choice and Change Is Possible

We can all choose our life path, and we constantly have to renew our choice. Our moral condition is not mechanically determined, locked into the consequences of our own or anyone else's past. God has given us real moral freedom and choice.

Our Moral Choices Have High Stakes: Life and Death

"At one level of Ezekiel's language life and death refer to judicial sentencing: either someone is declared innocent and leaves the court alive, or is declared guilty and put to death. However, in the earlier chapters (Ezek 4-11), life and death meant literally that: many would physically die in the destruction of Jerusalem. Yet it was not so simple, since doubtless some who grieved over Israel's sin were killed in the catastrophe, while some of the guilty idolaters survived physically but went off into the 'death' of exile, which reveals a

yet further twist: those addressed in exile are among the 'dead' (as they say of themselves in 37:11), and yet they can be offered 'life' if they will repent. Later in the book, 'life' means the eschatological hope of return and blessing back in the promised land, which will be explored in chs. 34-37."

Wright, Christopher J.H. (2001). [*The Message of Ezekiel: A New Heart and a New Spirit*](#). IVP Academic. 198-199.

Yahweh always wills that people find life through repentance and change (18:23, 32), but 18:31 raises a real problem (also raised by Moses in [Deut 30:1-10](#)): How can Israel make for itself a "new heart and spirit" when they clearly are incapable of doing so?

Ezekiel 19: Dirge Over the Lion and the Vine

Ezekiel picks up the traditional images from Genesis (especially [Gen. 49:8-12](#)) depicting the royal line as a lion (Gen. 49:9) and as a vine (see Gen. 49:11). He reverses the images of Gen 49 (lion captured, vine destroyed) and pronounces a funeral dirge over the Davidic line.

There is debate over the historical reference of the parable (does it refer to Jehoahaz and Zedekiah, or Jehoiakim and Jehoiachin?), but the theological claim of the poem is clear.

Three Generations of Righteous and Unrighteous

GEN 1: RIGHTEOUS DAD

— GEN 2: WICKED SON

GEN 3: RIGHTEOUS GRANDSON

Three Generations of Righteous and Unrighteous. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

Does God punish children for the sins of their parents? How does Ezekiel 18 inform your understanding of this?